

Nielsen Norman Group Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

Use this workbook to conduct your own heuristic evaluation.

For each of Jakob's 10 Usability Heuristics, look for specific places where the interface fails to adhere to the guideline. Write your recommendations for how to fix those usability issues.

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EVALUATOR: UX Reviewer

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PRODUCT: FYP Management System

TASK: Submit proposal, track mile:

1

Visibility of System Status

The design should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within a reasonable amount of time.

- Does the design clearly communicate its state?
- Is feedback presented quickly after user actions?

Issues

1. No loading indicators shown during data fetch on the Proposal Dashboard.
2. Task status badges (Active/Overdue) are tiny and hard to distinguish at a glance.
3. Progress bar on Milestone Submissions lacks a percentage label.
4. After form submission, no success/failure confirmation is shown.

Recommendations

1. Add a spinner or skeleton loader to dashboard cards while data loads.
2. Increase badge size and use distinct color coding (green=active, red=overdue) with text labels.
3. Add a percentage label (e.g. '60% complete') alongside the progress bar.
4. Show a toast notification confirming submission success or failure after every form action.

2

Match Between System and the Real World

The design should speak the users' language. Use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.

- Will user be familiar with the terminology used in the design?
- Do the design's controls follow real-world conventions?

Issues

1. Labels like 'Panel Assignment' and 'Milestone Creation' use system-oriented terminology unfamiliar to students.
2. The Evaluation screen uses abbreviations (SV, EV) without explanation.
3. Date fields show no format hint (DD/MM/YYYY vs MM/DD/YYYY).
4. Icon buttons in the nav bar lack text labels, relying solely on abstract icons.

Recommendations

1. Rename 'Panel Assignment' to 'Assign Examiners' and 'Milestone Creation' to 'Add Milestone' to match student mental models.
2. Replace abbreviations with full labels: 'Supervisor (SV)' and 'Examiner (EV)'.
3. Add placeholder text in date fields indicating the expected format (e.g. DD/MM/YYYY).
4. Add text labels below nav icons or include tooltips on hover.

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User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

- Does the design allow users to go back a step in the process?
- Are exit links easily discoverable?
- Can users easily cancel an action?
- Is *Undo* and *Redo* supported?

Issues

1. No visible 'Cancel' button on Milestone Creation or Panel Assignment forms — users must navigate away manually.
2. The Request Management table has no undo after approving or rejecting a request.
3. No breadcrumb or back navigation from detail views to the dashboard.
4. Once a milestone is submitted, no edit or withdraw option is visible.

Recommendations

1. Add a clearly labeled 'Cancel' button to all modal forms that returns users to the previous screen without saving.
2. Implement a short-window undo (e.g. 5-second snackbar) after approve/reject actions.
3. Add breadcrumb navigation at the top of each page (e.g. Dashboard > Milestones > Create).
4. Allow milestone editing until a cut-off date and show an 'Edit' button on submitted entries.

4

Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

- Does the design follow industry conventions?
- Are visual treatments used consistently throughout the design?

Issues

1. Button styles are inconsistent — some actions use blue, others teal or orange (e.g. 'Save Draft' vs 'Submit').
2. Table row spacing differs across User Management, Request Management, and View Submissions.
3. Modals on Milestone Creation and Panel Assignment have different header styles and close icon positions.
4. The 'Add New' button appears in different positions across pages.

Recommendations

1. Define a consistent color system: one primary action color (blue) and one secondary; avoid orange or teal for actions unless indicating warnings.
2. Standardize table row height and padding across all list/table views.
3. Create a single modal template with consistent header size, close icon (top-right), and button layout.
4. Fix the 'Add New' button to always appear in the top-right corner of its section.

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Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

- Does the design prevent slips by using helpful constraints?
- Does the design warn users before they perform risky actions?

Issues

1. The Milestone Creation form allows submission with empty required fields, with no inline validation.
2. Panel Assignment does not warn if the same examiner is assigned to too many projects.
3. Deleting a user in User Management has no confirmation dialog.
4. The form accepts past dates as milestone deadlines without a warning.

Recommendations

1. Add inline validation to required fields; disable the Submit button until all required fields are complete.
2. Show a warning if an examiner exceeds the maximum number of assigned projects.
3. Add a confirmation dialog before any destructive action: 'Delete this user? This cannot be undone.'
4. Disable past dates in the date picker and show an inline error if a past date is entered manually.

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Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user's memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. The user should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. Information required to use the design (e.g. field labels or menu items) should be visible or easily retrievable when needed.

- Does the design keep important information visible, so that users do not have to memorize it?
- Does the design offer help in-context?

Issues

1. The Evaluation page requires users to remember scoring criteria — no rubric is visible during grading.
2. Sidebar navigation icons have no text labels, forcing users to memorize icon meanings.
3. The 'Input Grades' modal shows student names but not their project title, requiring the grader to recall which project belongs to whom.
4. Filter and sort options in tables are hidden behind unlabeled icon buttons.

Recommendations

1. Display the grading rubric directly on the Evaluation page as a collapsible side panel.
2. Add text labels beneath each sidebar icon, or expand the sidebar to show labels by default.
3. Show both student name and project title in the 'Input Grades' modal header.
4. Show filter/sort as visible labeled dropdowns or chips rather than icon-only buttons.

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Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts — hidden from novice users — may speed up the interaction for the expert user such that the design can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users. Allow users to tailor frequent actions.

- Does the design provide accelerators like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures?
- Is content and functionality personalized or customized for individual users?

Issues

1. No keyboard shortcuts for common actions (e.g. creating a milestone, approving a request).
2. The dashboard is not customizable — users cannot pin frequently accessed sections.
3. Bulk actions (approve multiple requests, assign multiple panels) are not supported.
4. No search bar on User Management or View Submissions pages.

Recommendations

1. Introduce keyboard shortcuts for power users (e.g. 'N' = new milestone, 'A' = approve selected).
2. Allow users to customize the dashboard by pinning or reordering widgets.
3. Add checkboxes to table rows to enable bulk approve, reject, or assign actions.
4. Add a search bar to User Management and View Submissions to quickly locate records.

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Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.

- Is the visual design and content focused on the essentials?
- Have all distracting, unnecessary elements been removed?

Issues

1. The Proposal Dashboard shows too many stat cards simultaneously with no clear hierarchy, creating cognitive overload.
2. The Announcements panel shows full body text in the list, making it excessively long.
3. The Feedback & Grades page shows all scores and progress bars at once without grouping.
4. The login page sidebar contains excessive decorative text distracting from the login form.

Recommendations

1. Reduce dashboard stat cards to the 3 most critical KPIs; move secondary metrics to a collapsible section.
2. Truncate announcement body text to 1-2 lines with a 'Read more' link.
3. Group grades by category (supervisor, examiner) and collapse breakdowns by default.
4. Simplify the login page sidebar to a short tagline and one key visual.

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Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.

- Does the design use traditional error message visuals, like bold, red text?
- Does the design offer a solution that solves the error immediately?

Issues

1. No inline error messages appear on form fields when validation fails — the form silently refuses to submit.
2. If a network error occurs, no error state or retry option is shown on the dashboard.
3. Failed file uploads are not visually differentiated from normal states.
4. The login form shows no message when credentials are incorrect — the form simply resets.

Recommendations

1. Display field-level error messages in red text below each invalid field (e.g. 'Title is required').
2. Add an error banner with a 'Retry' button when data fails to load due to network issues.
3. Show a red border and error icon on failed file upload fields with a clear explanation (e.g. 'File too large. Max 5MB').
4. Display a plain-language error on the login form: 'Incorrect email or password. Please try again.'

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Help and Documentation

It's best if the system doesn't need any additional explanation. However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users understand how to complete their tasks.

- Is help documentation easy to search?
- Is help provided in context right at the moment when the user requires it?

Issues

1. No help documentation, FAQ, or user guide is accessible from within the application.
2. Complex forms (Milestone Creation, Evaluation grading) have no tooltips or contextual help text.
3. There is no onboarding walkthrough or guided tour for first-time users.
4. The Announcements section does not indicate who to contact for further help or support.

Recommendations

1. Add a '?' help icon in the nav bar linking to a searchable help centre or user guide.
2. Add tooltip icons next to complex form fields explaining what is expected (e.g. 'Milestone title should describe the deliverable').
3. Implement a brief onboarding tour on first login that highlights key sections of the dashboard.
4. Include a 'Contact Support' link or email address in the footer and on the Announcements page.